



1.e)

David Schneider idea of symbols

David Schneider belongs to Symbolic school of anthropology which sees culture as an aggregation of symbols and which have specific meaning in the minds of people.

He defined culture as a "system of symbols & further defined symbol as simply 'something which stands for something else'".

He gave a 'Taxonomical approach': According to him culture is a system of several classes of symbols like economic symbols, political etc which are inter-related & in totality represent culture.

In his book 'American Kinship' :- he studies middle class residents of Chicago. Here he departs from the genealogical studies & studies kinship using symbolic approach. He says that

'blood' has been an everlasting symbol in kinship studies. However, kins are decided not just by blood relation (i.e. being) but also by cultural, social relations (i.e. doing).

Unlike Gertz & Turner, who make complete break from structuralism, he retained and modified Levi Strauss ideas of culture as a set of relationships.

Criticisms :

- 1) Criticised for unscientific nature of study
- 2) Marxists : over emphasis on symbols & social realities largely ignore.

Despite criticism, Schneider added a more humanistic & interpretative approach to anthropological study steering away from rigid scientific methods.